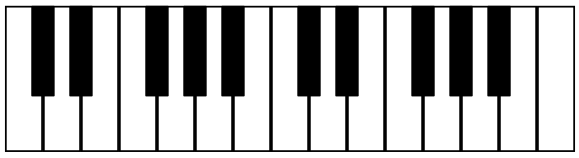
Read at Sight

A graded sight-reading course for piano

Volume 3 - Two Voices



Middle C

The left hand gets its own music: broken chords, Alberti basses and real second voices, in 6/8 time and in keys with up to two sharps or flats.

Exercises generated to graded rules; pieces are original or public domain.

How to use this book

What is new in Volume 3

In Volumes 1 and 2 the left hand mostly held long notes while the right hand played the tune. Now both hands have something to say. The left hand plays broken chords and Alberti basses, then a melody of its own, and the right hand starts to play two notes at once. You will also meet 6/8 time, the keys of D major and B-flat major, and sharps and flats that are not in the key signature. Start this book when you can read Volume 2 music, with shifts, dotted rhythms and dynamics, in C, G and F major and their relative minors.

The five rules

1. Never stop: keep the beat going, even after a wrong note. 2. Count out loud and use a metronome at the speed shown. 3. Keep your eyes on the music, not your hands. 4. Read the shape: up, down, or the same, and by how much. 5. Play each exercise once, tick its box, and move on. Come back only after a few weeks.

Before every exercise: 10 seconds

Check the clef and time signature. Find the first note and its finger number. Scan for the highest and lowest note, and for any bar that repeats an earlier one. Then count one bar in and play.

How each unit is laid out

A unit opens with what is new, a keyboard picture of the hand position, and reading tips. Then come Parts A, B and C, which grow slightly harder. Pieces come next, and the unit ends with a checkpoint that tells you when to move on.

A daily routine (15-20 minutes)

Warm up by playing the five notes of the hand position up and down, saying their names (2 minutes). Read 6-10 new exercises, one pass each (10 minutes). Play one piece, aiming for steady and musical (5 minutes).

Contents

Each unit adds exactly one new idea to everything before it.

Unit 1 Broken Chords 4
Triads; the left hand plays I, IV and V7 one note at a time

Unit 2 The Alberti Bass
Broken chords in eighth notes: low, high, middle, high

Unit 3 Six-Eight Time
6/8: two beats in a bar, each beat split into three eighths

Unit 4 D Major
Two sharps (F-sharp and C-sharp); D major and its chords

Unit 5 B-flat Major
Two flats (B-flat and E-flat); B-flat major and its chords

Unit 6 Accidentals
Sharps, flats and naturals inside the bar; the raised 7th in minor keys

Unit 7 Two Notes at Once
Right-hand thirds and sixths: reading two notes together

Unit 8 Two Independent Voices
A left-hand melody against the right hand: contrary and parallel motion

Unit 9 Imitation
Simple counterpoint: one hand answers the other with the same tune

Unit 10 Review
Everything in Volume 3 together

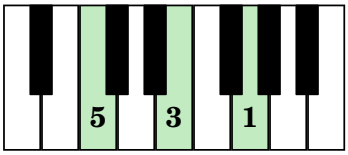
Unit 1

Broken Chords

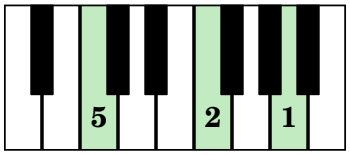
New: Triads; the left hand plays I, IV and V7 one note at a time

Until now the left hand mostly held one long note while the right hand played the tune. In this unit the left hand plays chords, one note at a time. A chord played one note after another is called a broken chord. Broken chords fill out the music and keep it moving, and they are easy to read once you know their shapes.
Each key uses three chord shapes. Learn them on the keyboard below before you start: in every exercise the left hand plays only these notes.

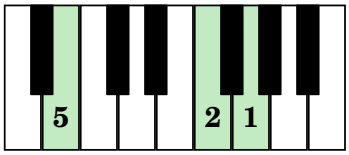
C major: left-hand chord shapes



I = C

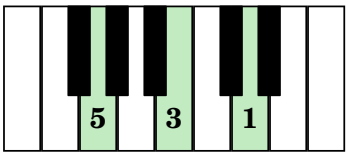


IV = F

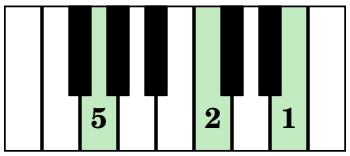


V7 = G7

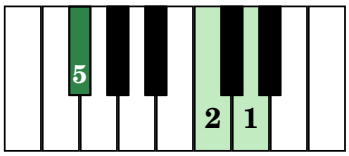
G major: left-hand chord shapes



I = G

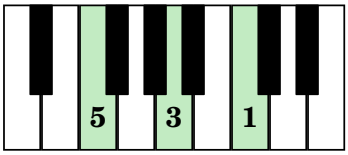


IV = C

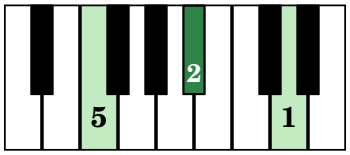


V7 = D7

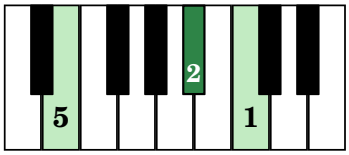
F major: left-hand chord shapes



I = F

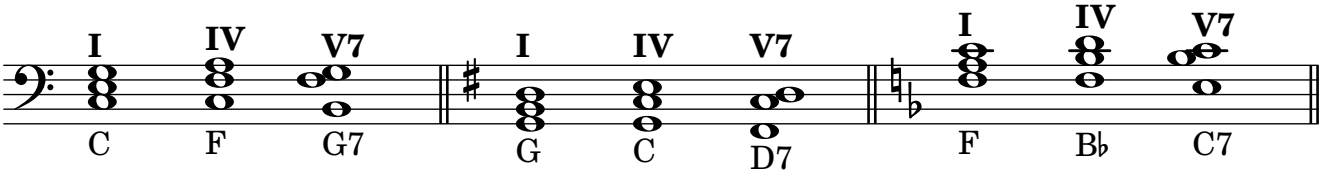


IV = B♭



V7 = C7

The same shapes on the staff



What is new

Triad

Three notes stacked in thirds: a note, the note a third above it, and the note a third above that. On the staff a triad sits on three lines in a row or in three spaces in a row: C E G, F A C, G B D.

I, IV and V7

Chords are named by the scale note they are built on: I on the first note of the key (C in C major), IV on the fourth (F) and V on the fifth (G). V7 adds a fourth note, a seventh above the bottom note (G B D F). The three chords together can play under most simple tunes.

Shapes that stay close

The hand does not jump to each new chord. It keeps finger 5 near the tonic and changes shape: I is C E G (fingers 5 3 1), IV is C F A (5 2 1) and V7 is B F G (5 2 1), which is G7 without its D. Finger 5 moves down one key for V7.

Broken-chord patterns

In 4/4 the left hand plays bottom, middle, top, middle in quarter notes. In 3/4 it plays bottom, middle, top. The last bar holds the tonic.

Finger numbers in the bass

A finger number under a bass note marks a new chord shape. Change the shape of your hand there, not before.

Reading tips

1. Read the left hand in shapes, not note by note: three lines or three spaces in a row is I; a wider shape is IV or V7.

2. In your 10-second scan, follow the left hand's finger numbers and name each chord: I, IV or V7.

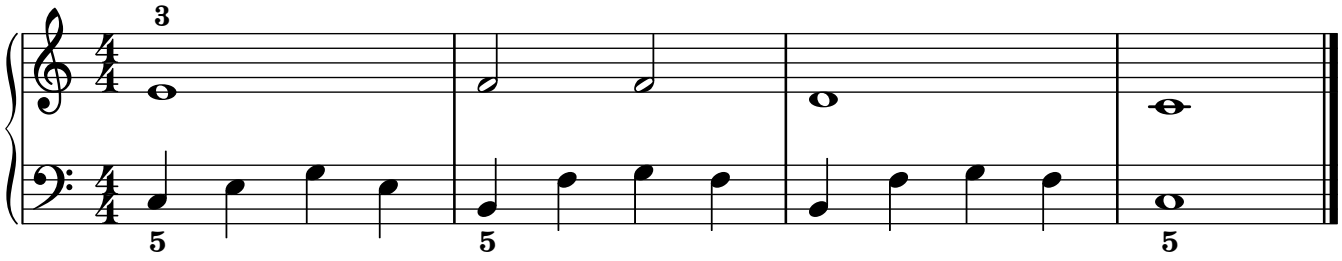
3. The first note of each bar in the right hand belongs to that bar's chord, so the hands always fit together on beat 1.

4. Keep the left hand soft and even. The tune is in the right hand.
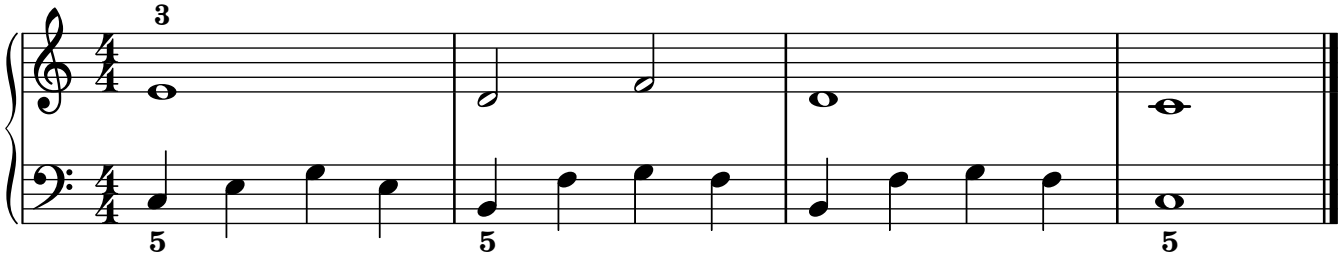
Part A: Two chords under long notes ♩ = 60

C major. The right hand plays half and whole notes; the left hand plays I and V7. Metronome 60.

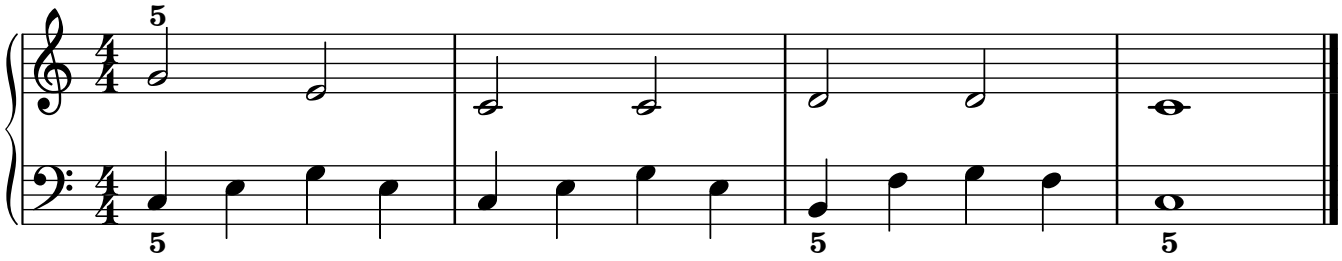
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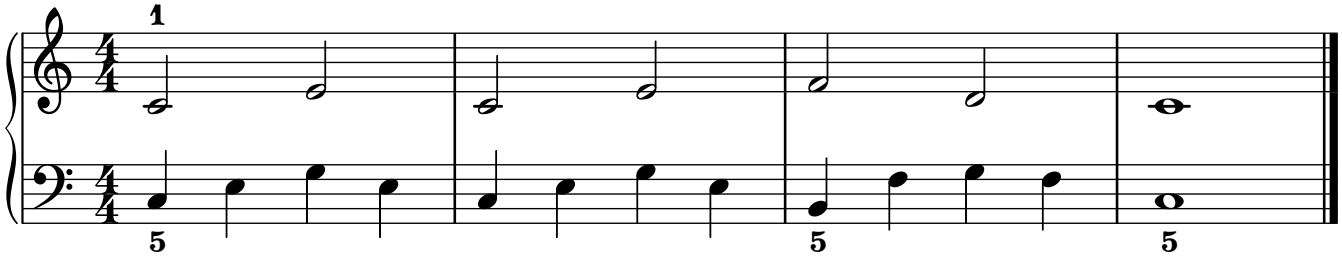
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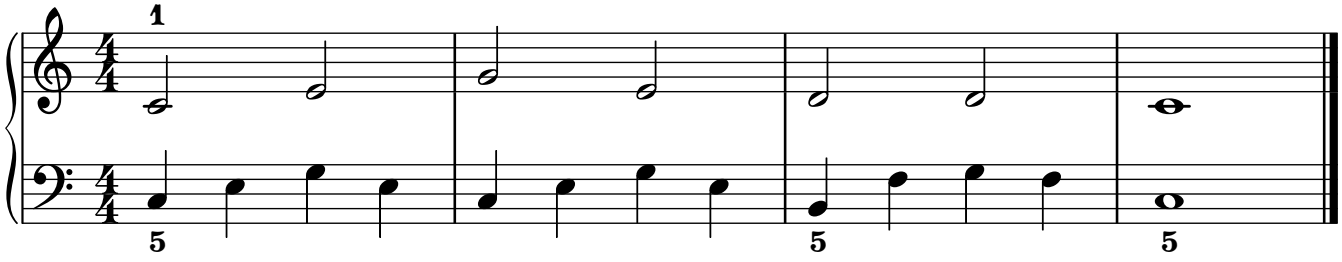
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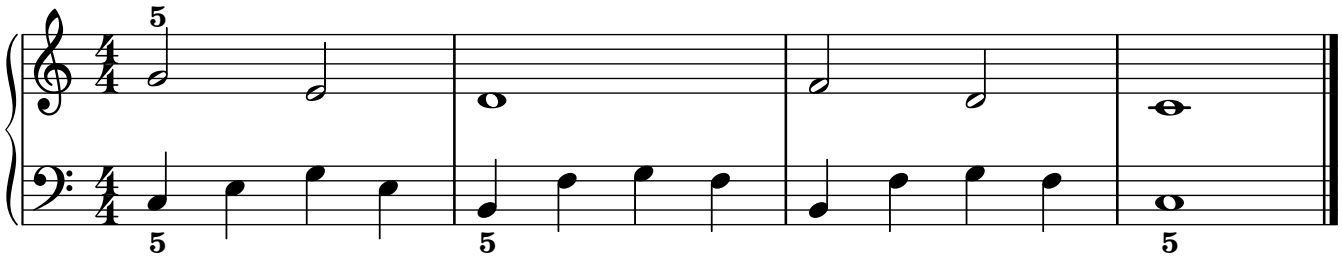
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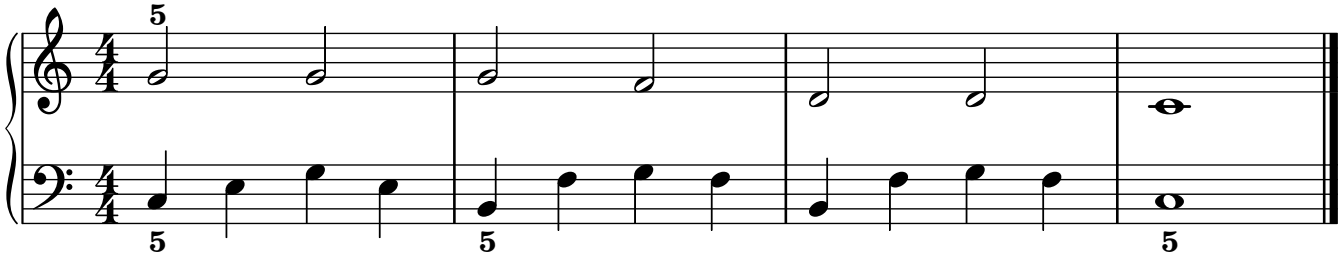
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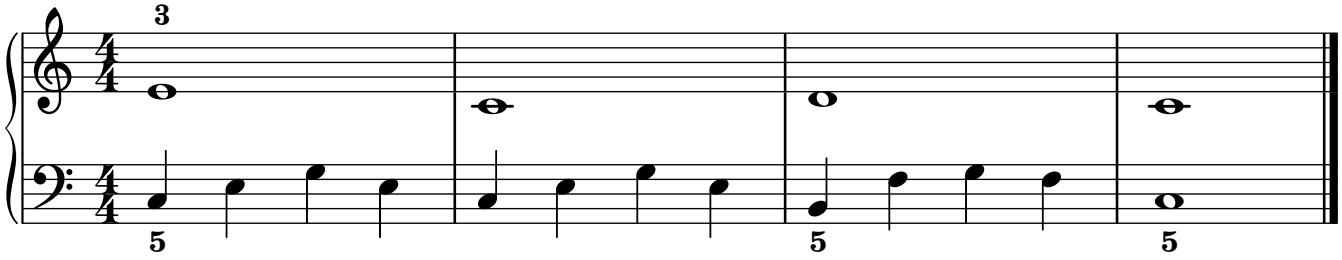
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☐ **1.7**
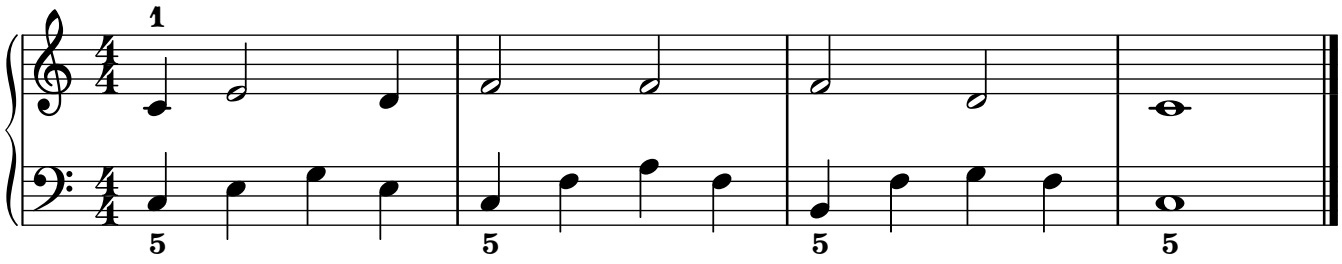


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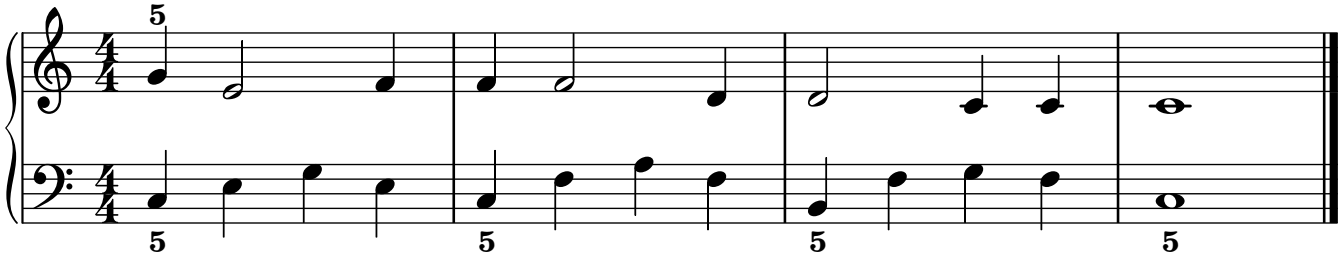
Part B: Adding the IV chord ♩ = 60

C major with all three chords. Every exercise goes I, IV, V7 and back to I.

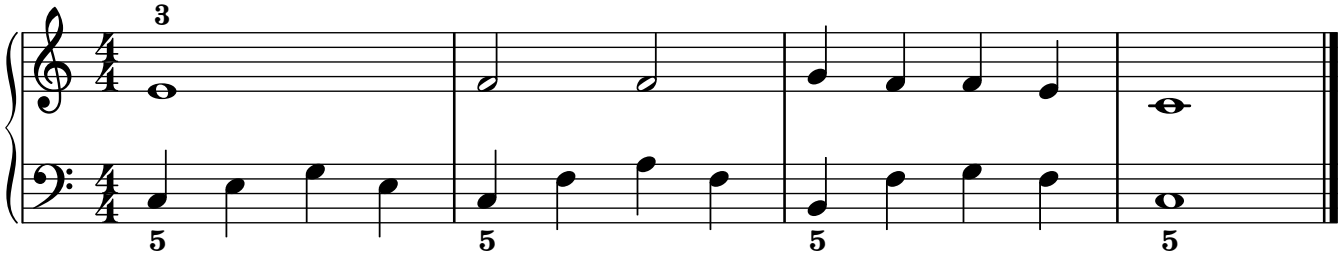
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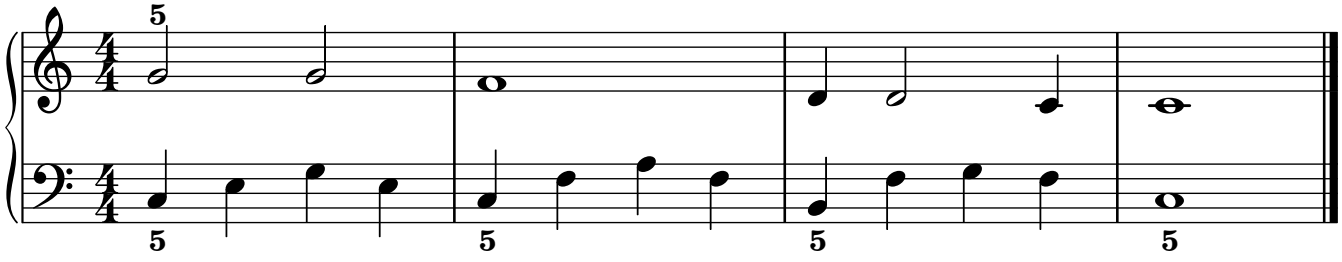
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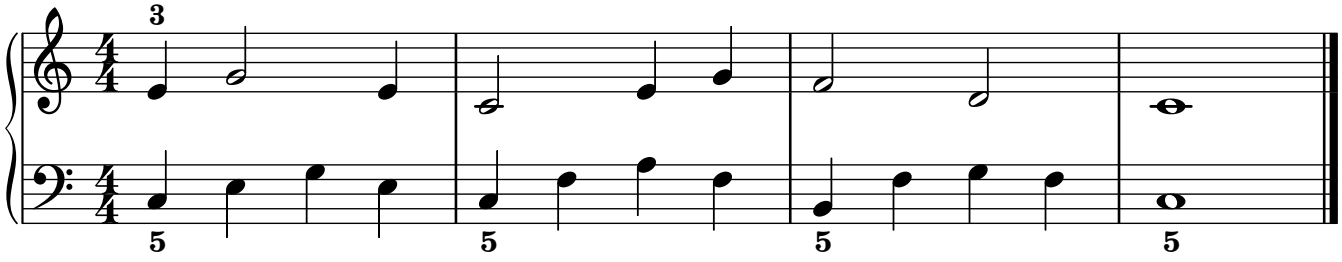
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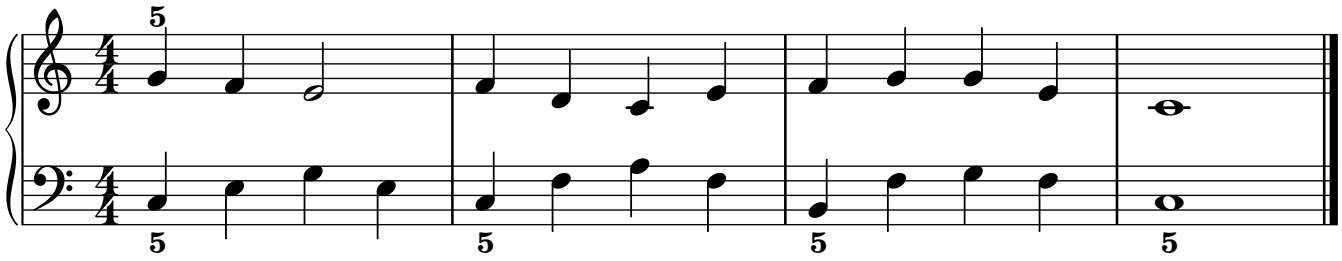
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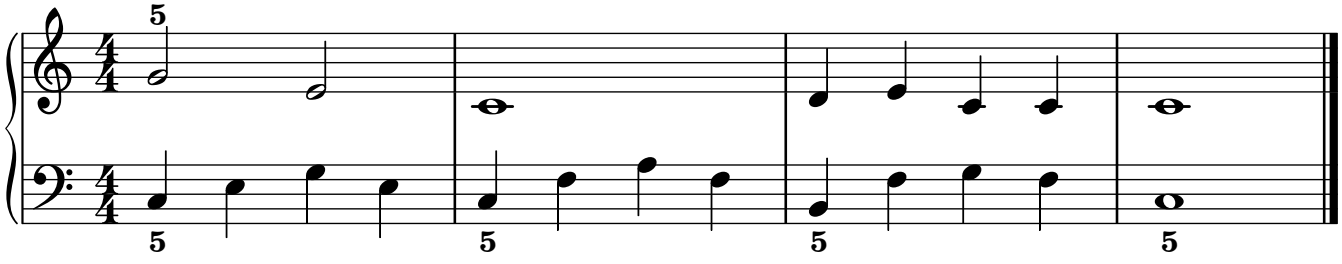
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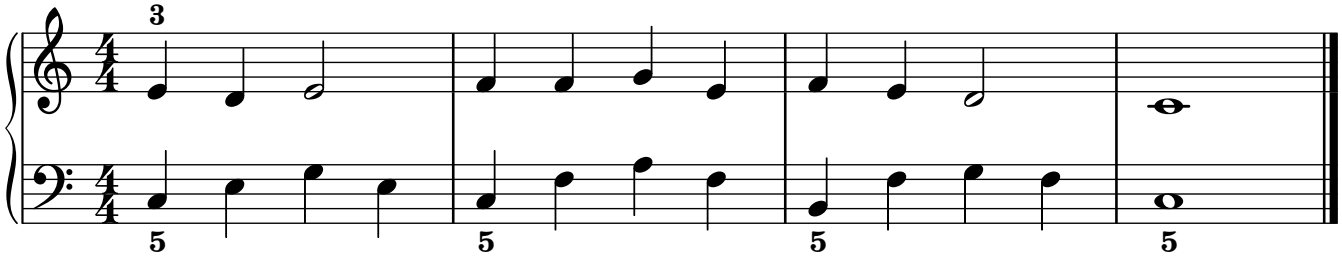
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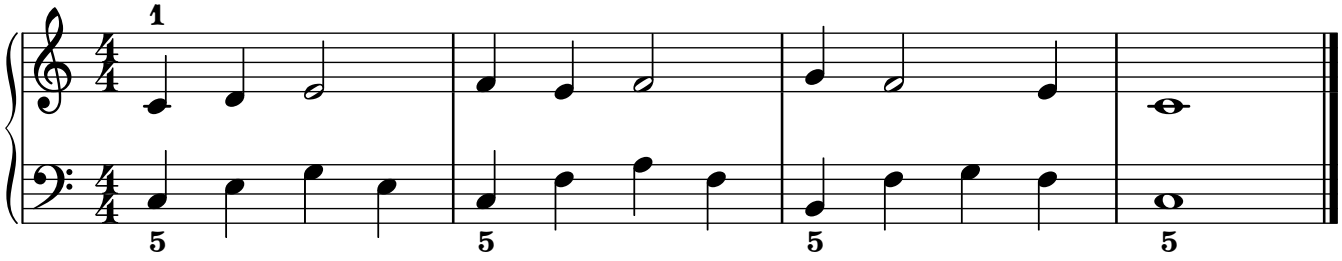
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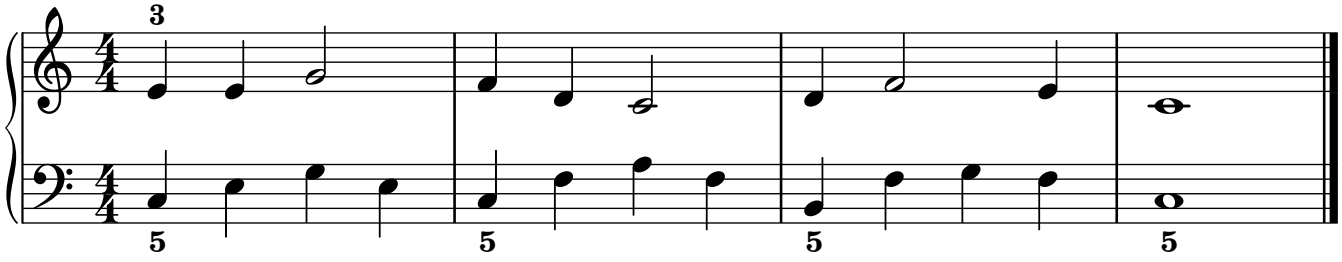
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☐ **1.17**



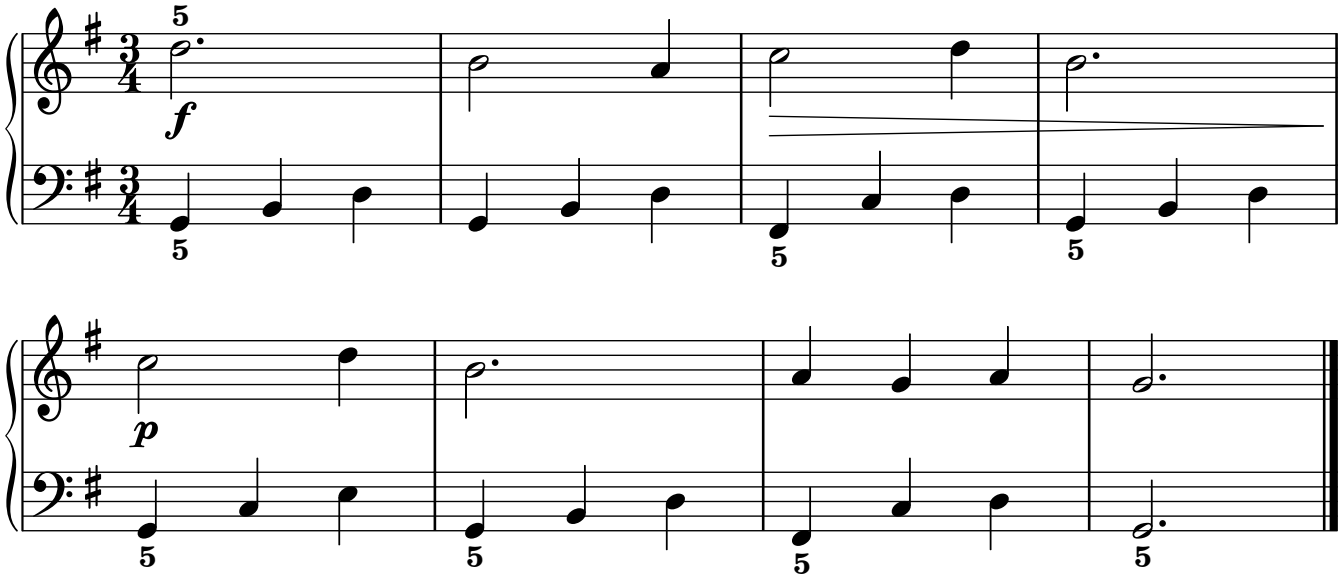
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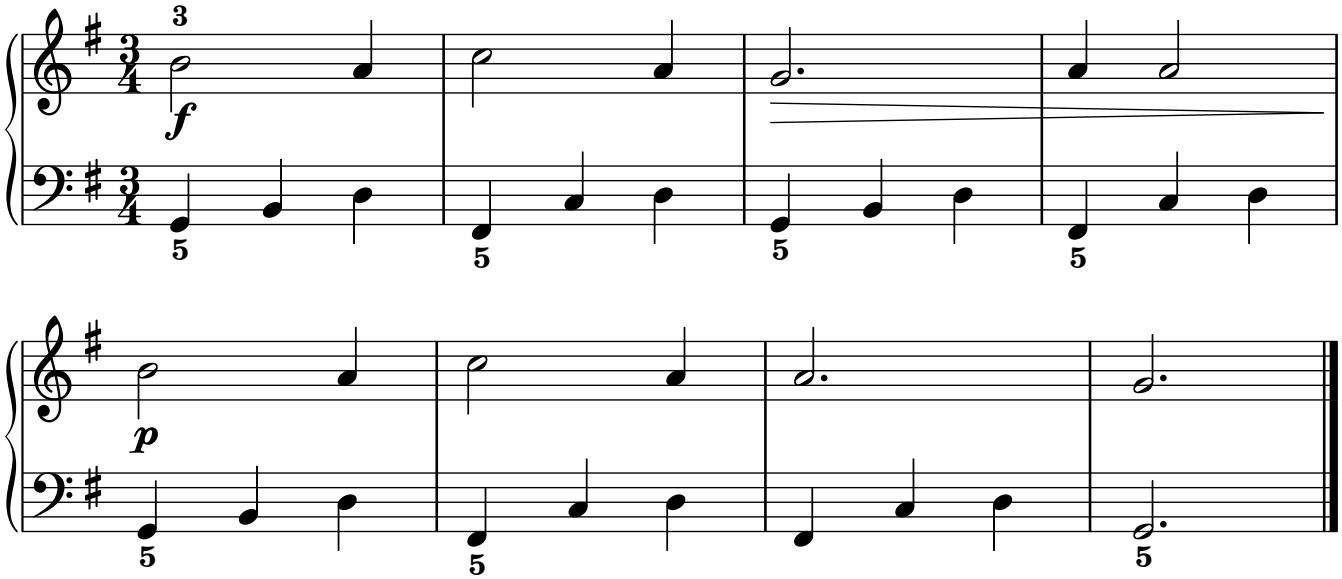


Part C: Waltz bass in G major ♩ = 72

G major waltzes: the left hand plays bottom, middle, top. F-sharp is the bottom note of the V7 shape.
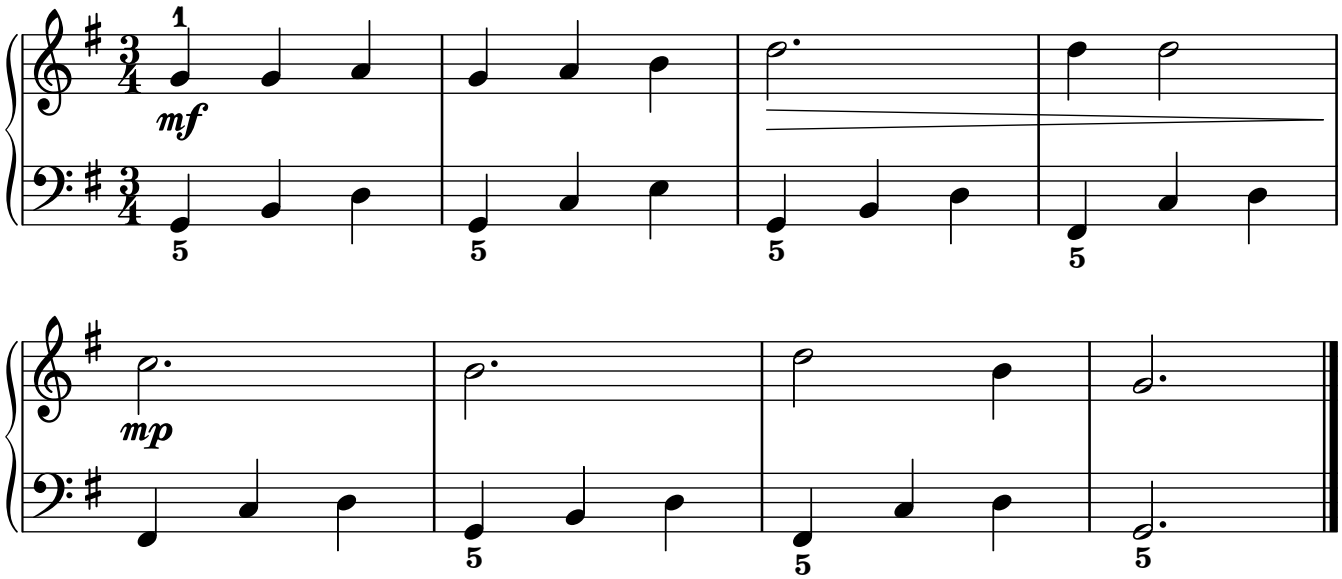
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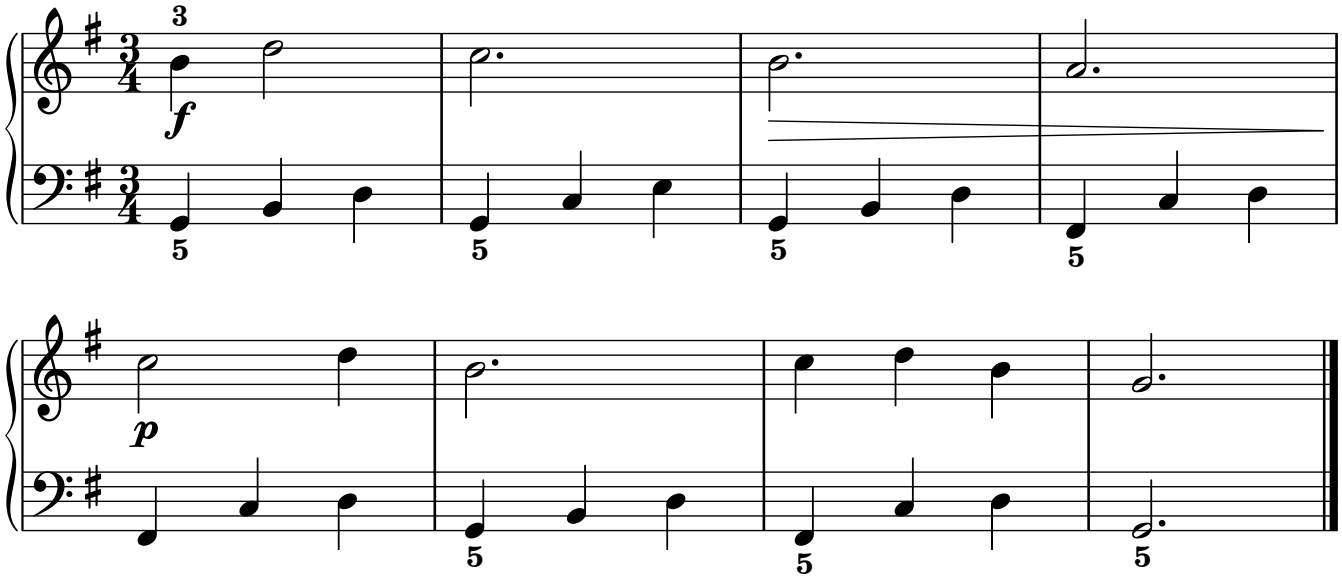
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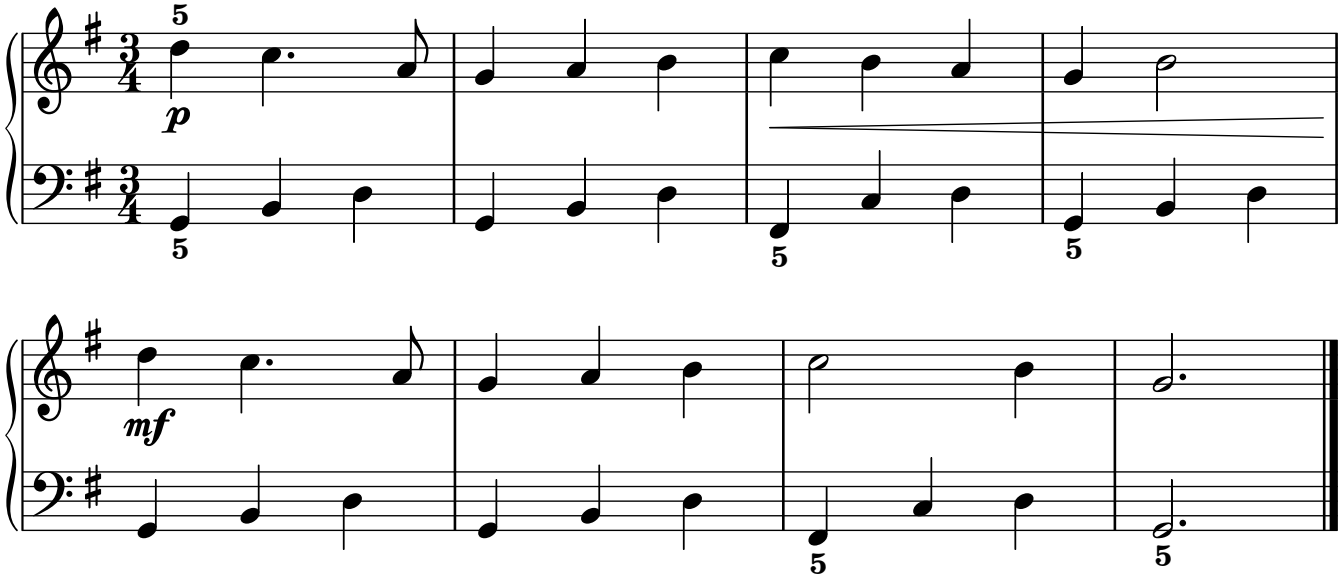


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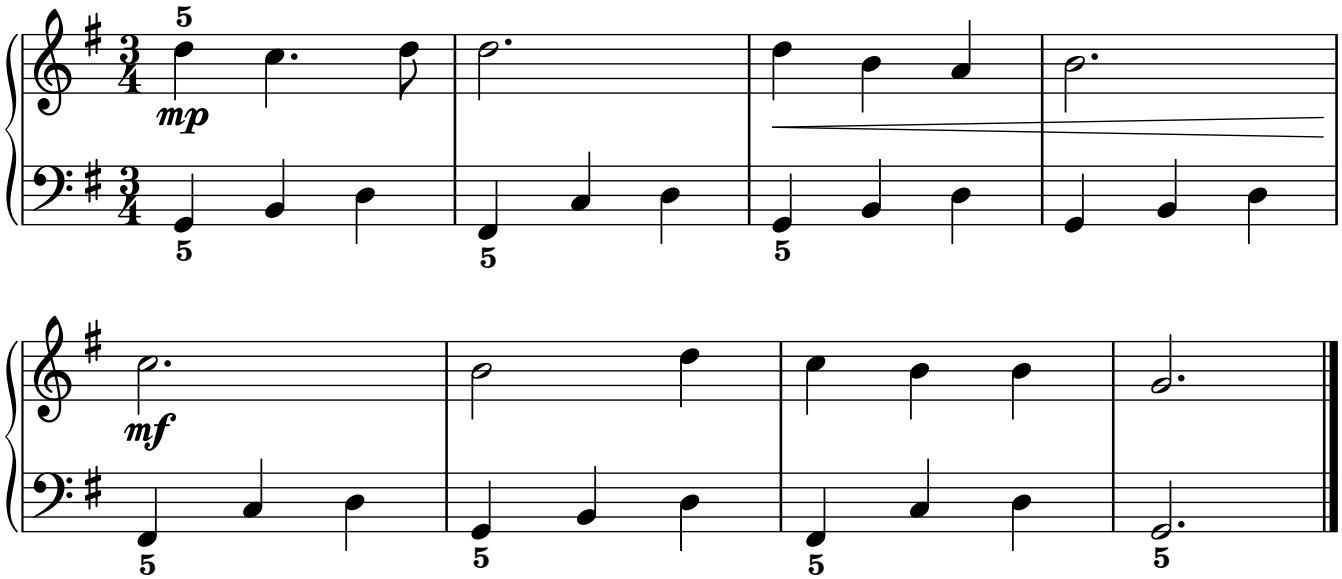
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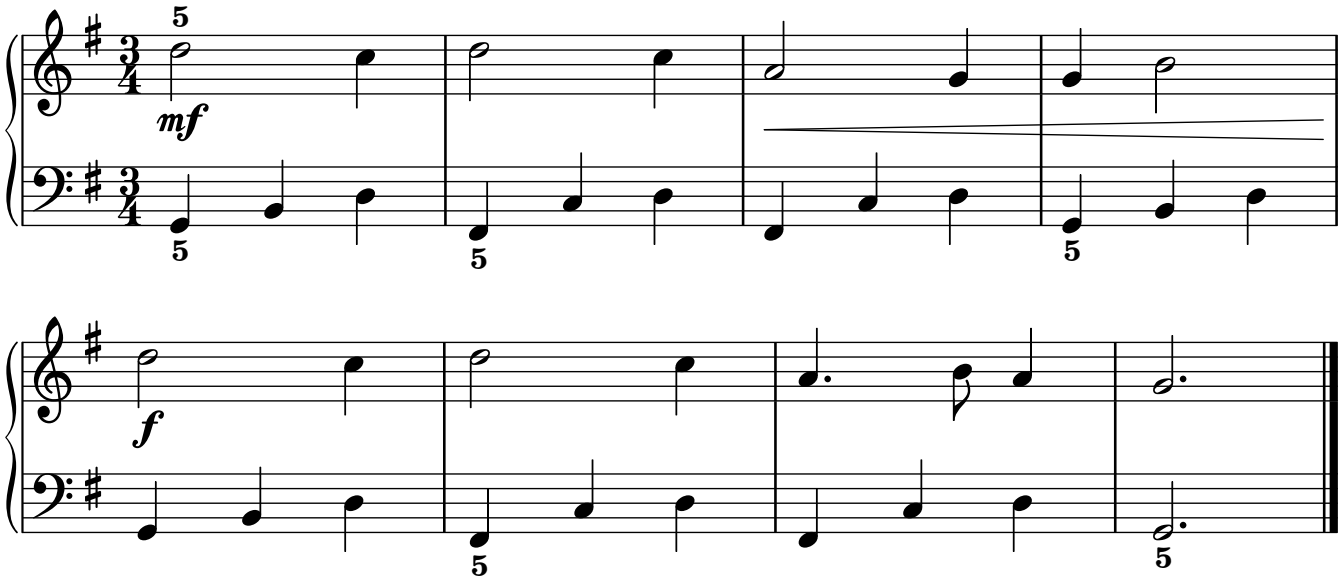
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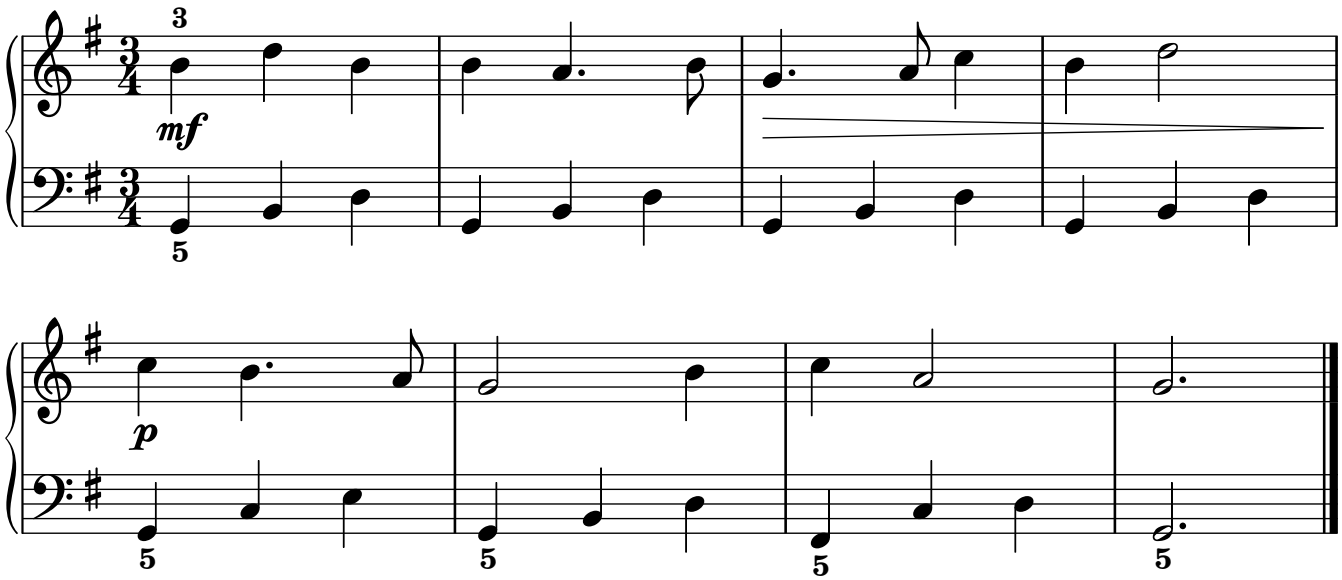
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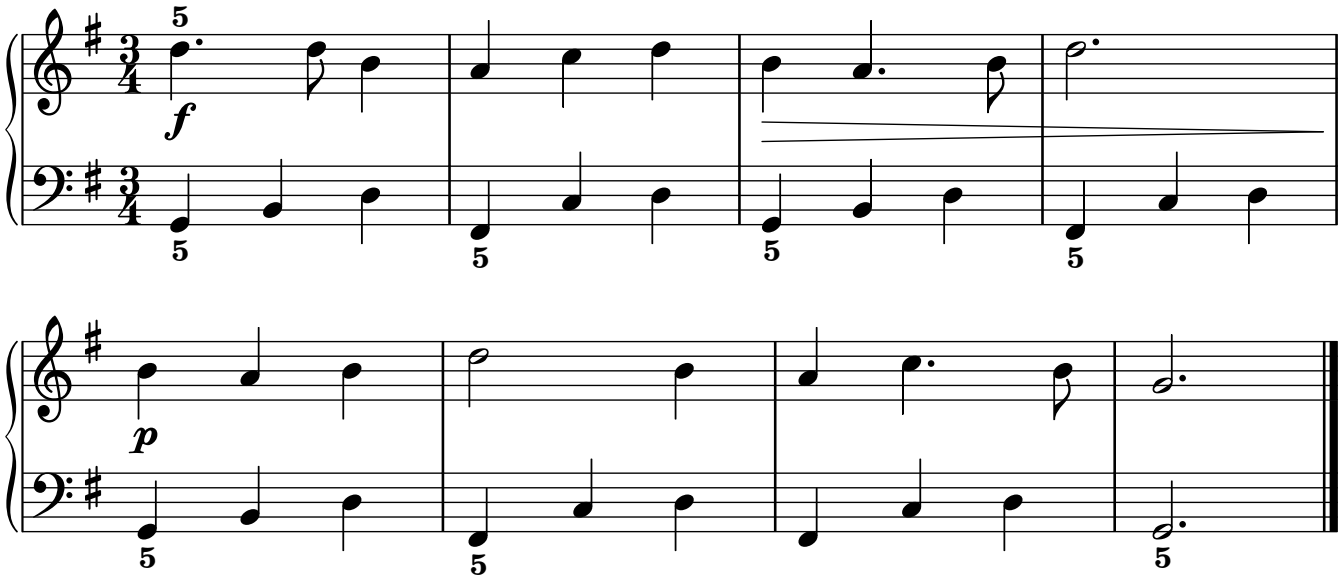


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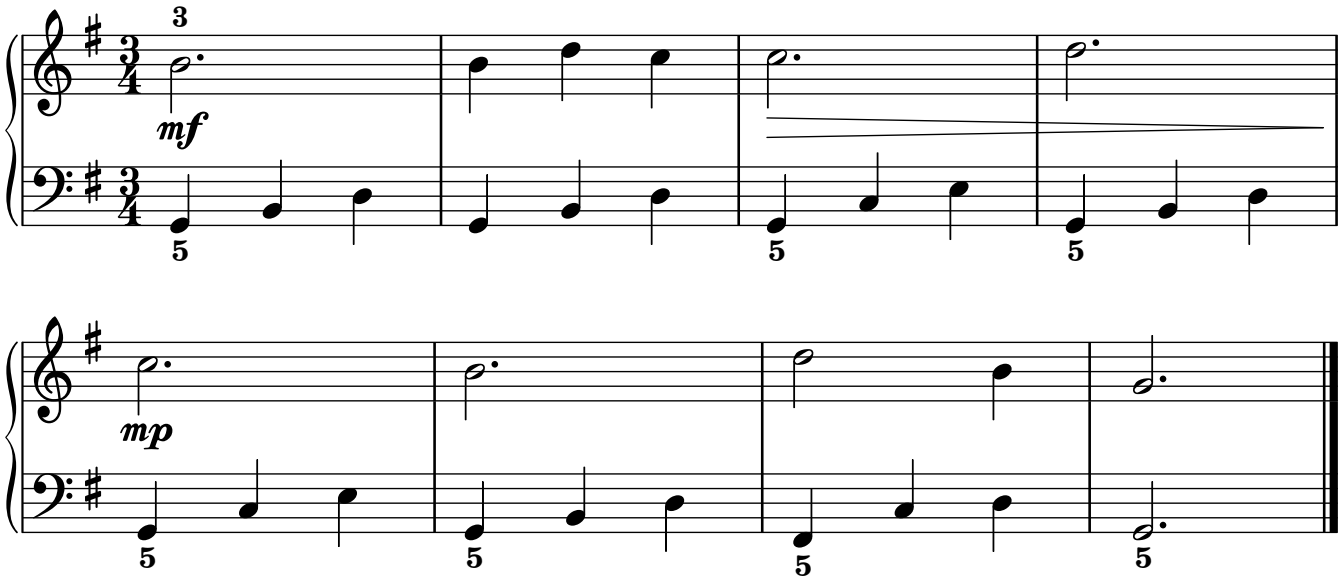
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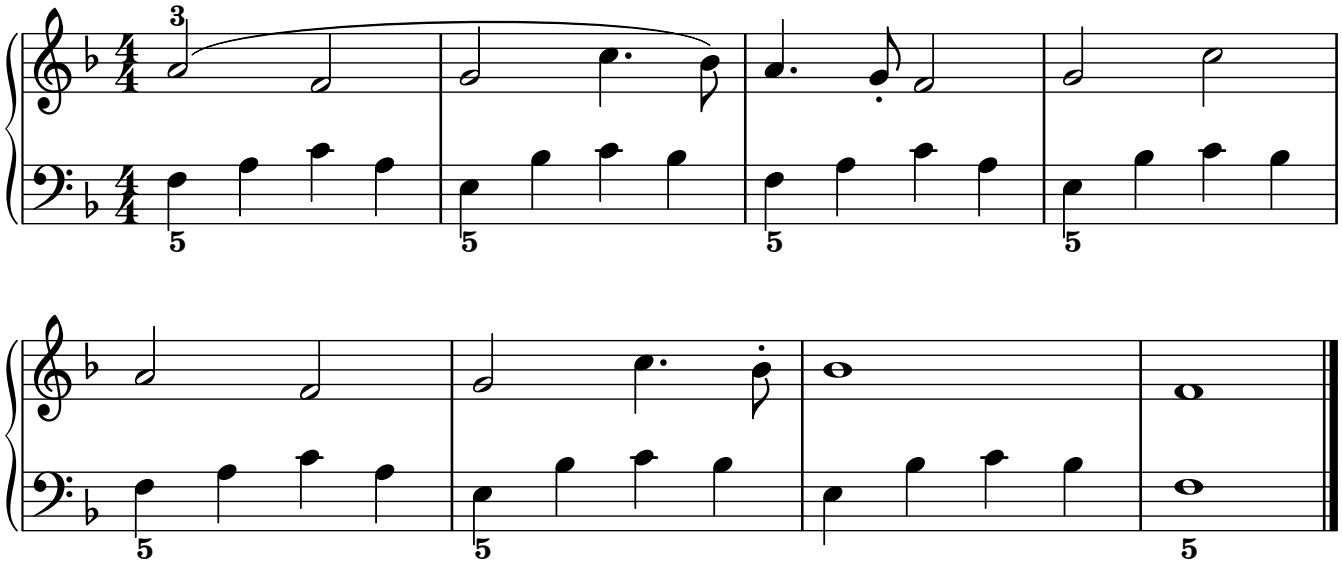
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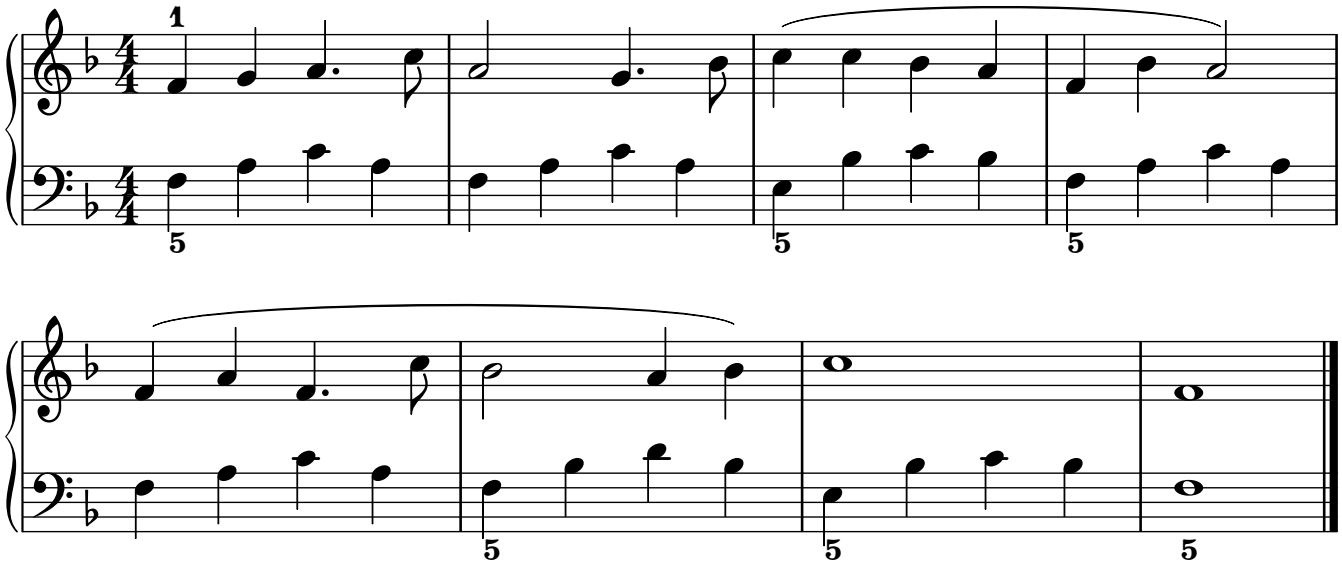


Part D: Eight bars in F major ♩ = 66

F major in eight bars. B-flat is the middle note of IV and V7. Watch the slurs and staccato dots.

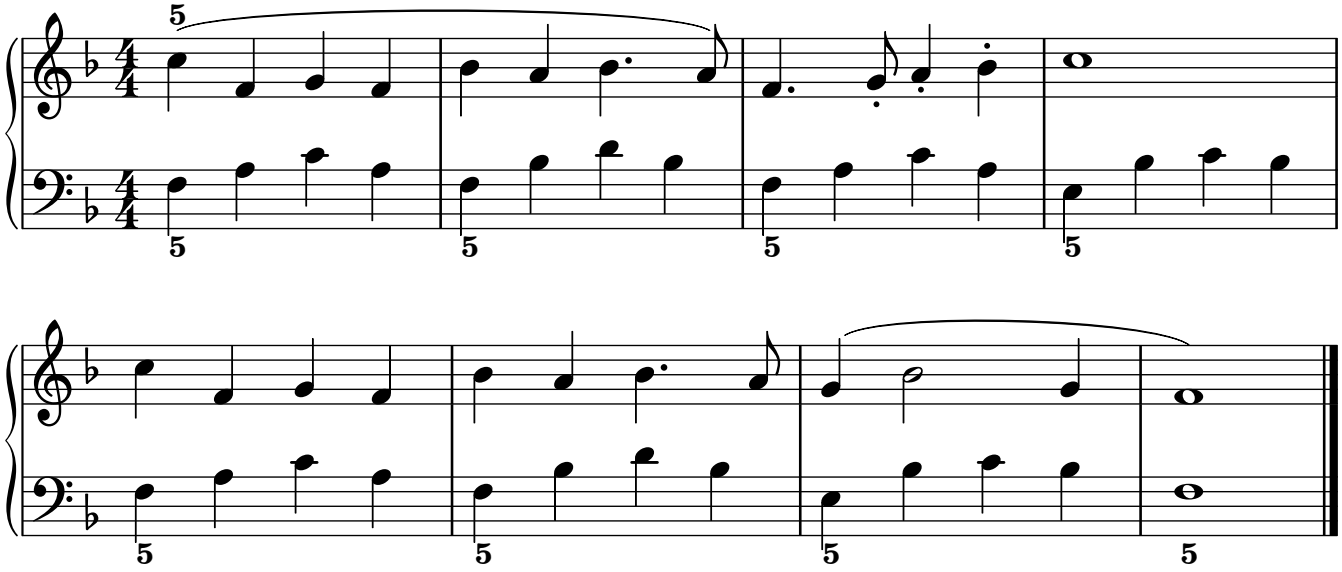
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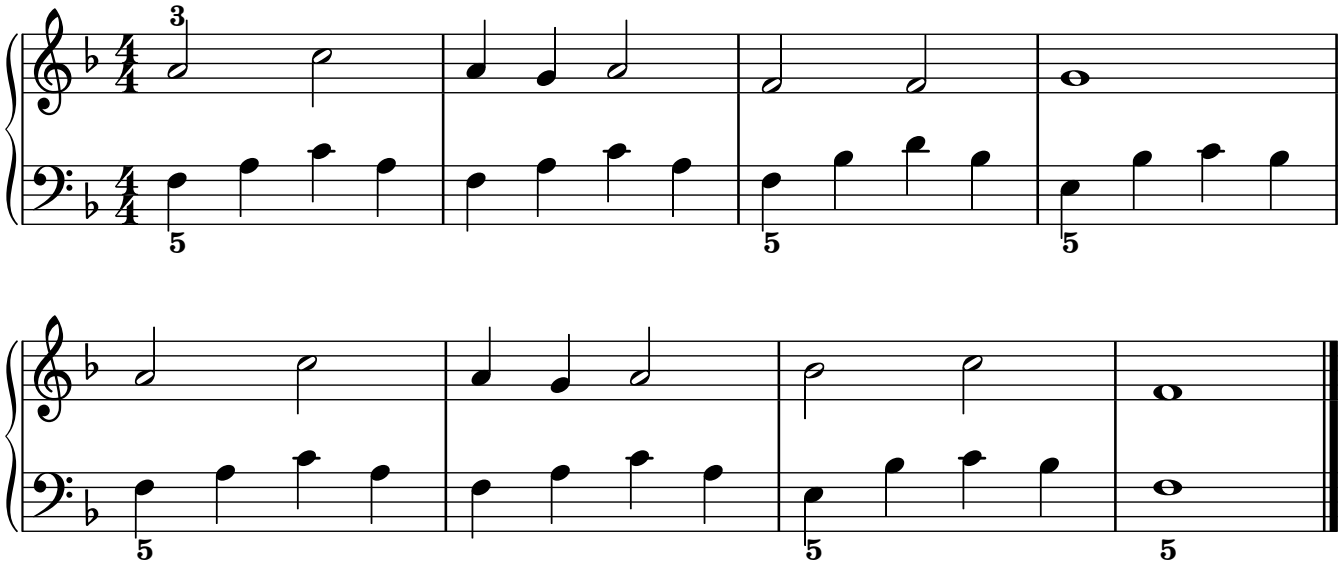
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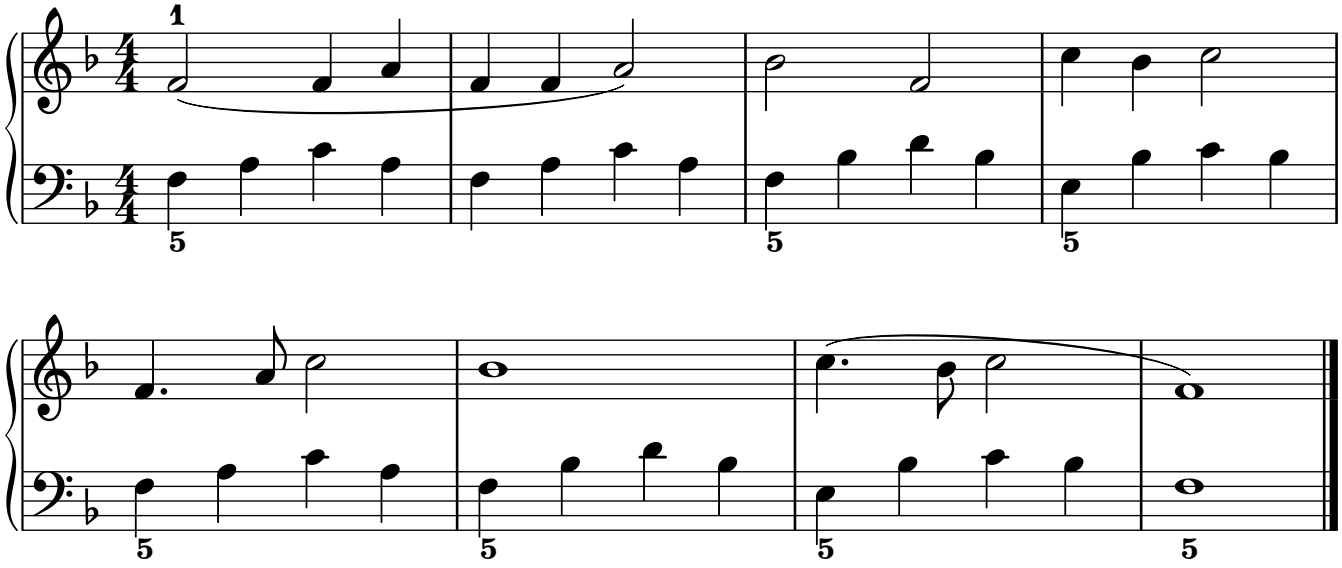
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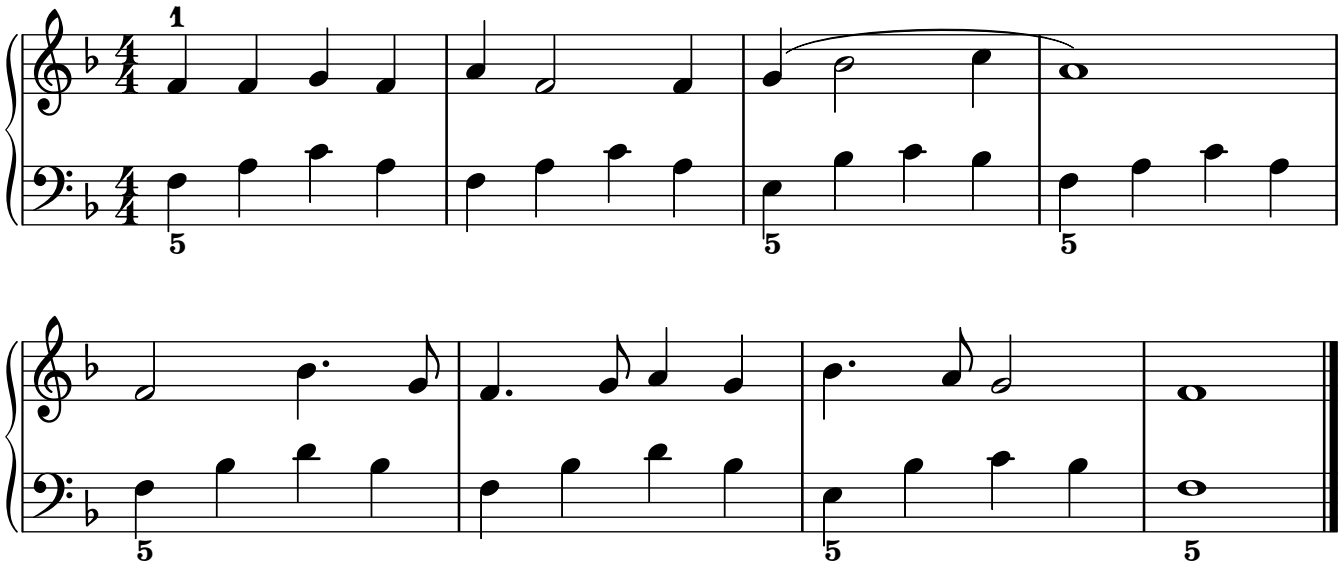
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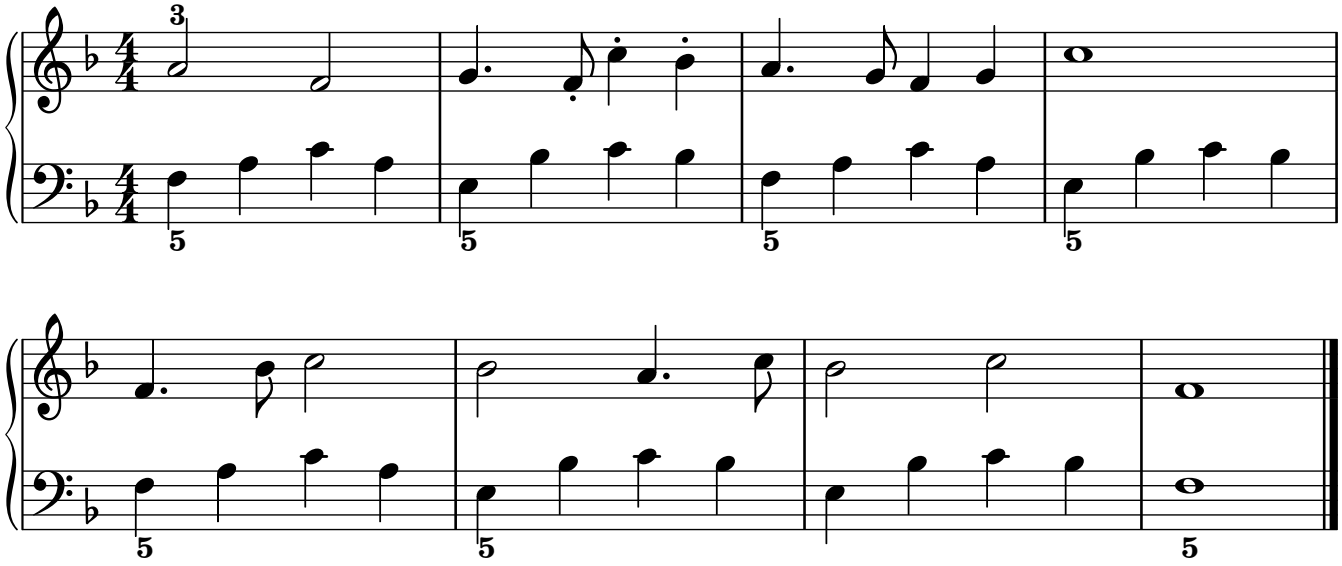
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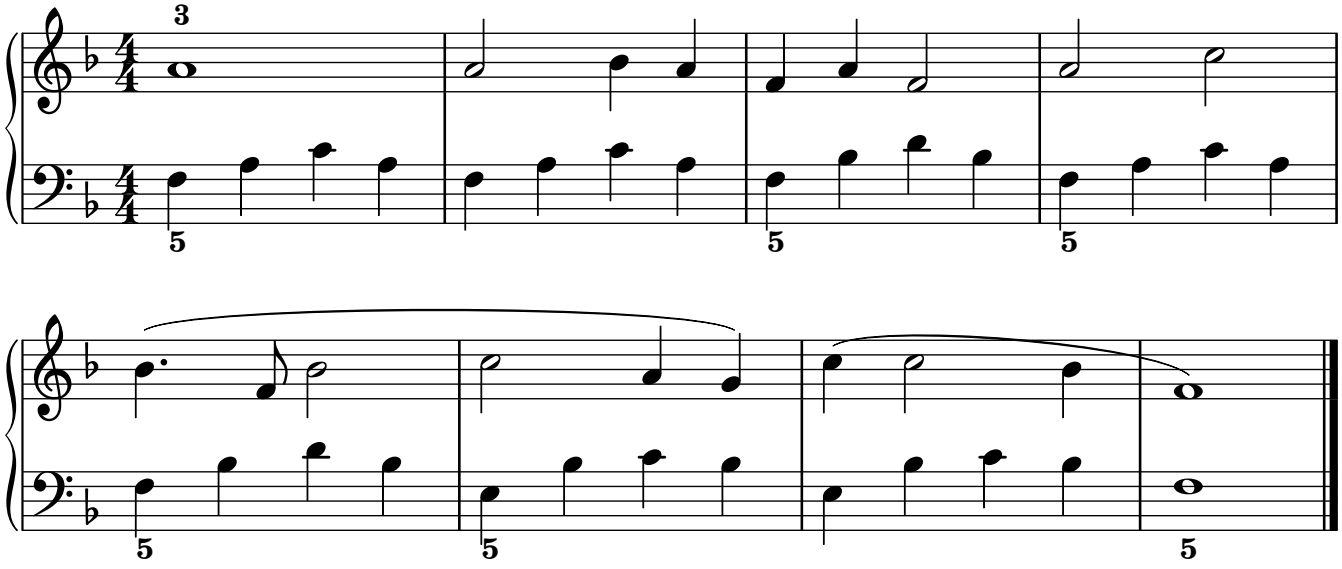
☐ **1.34**



☐ **1.35**



☐ **1.36**



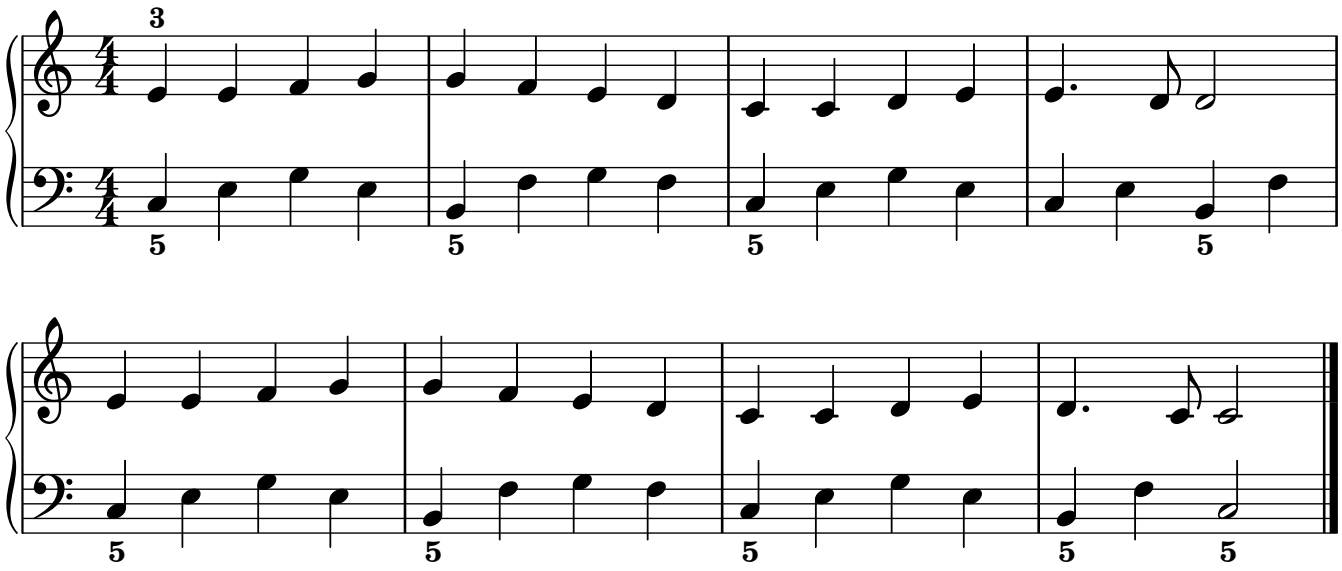
Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

Ode to Joy ♩ = 76

Ludwig van Beethoven, theme from Symphony No. 9 - simplified
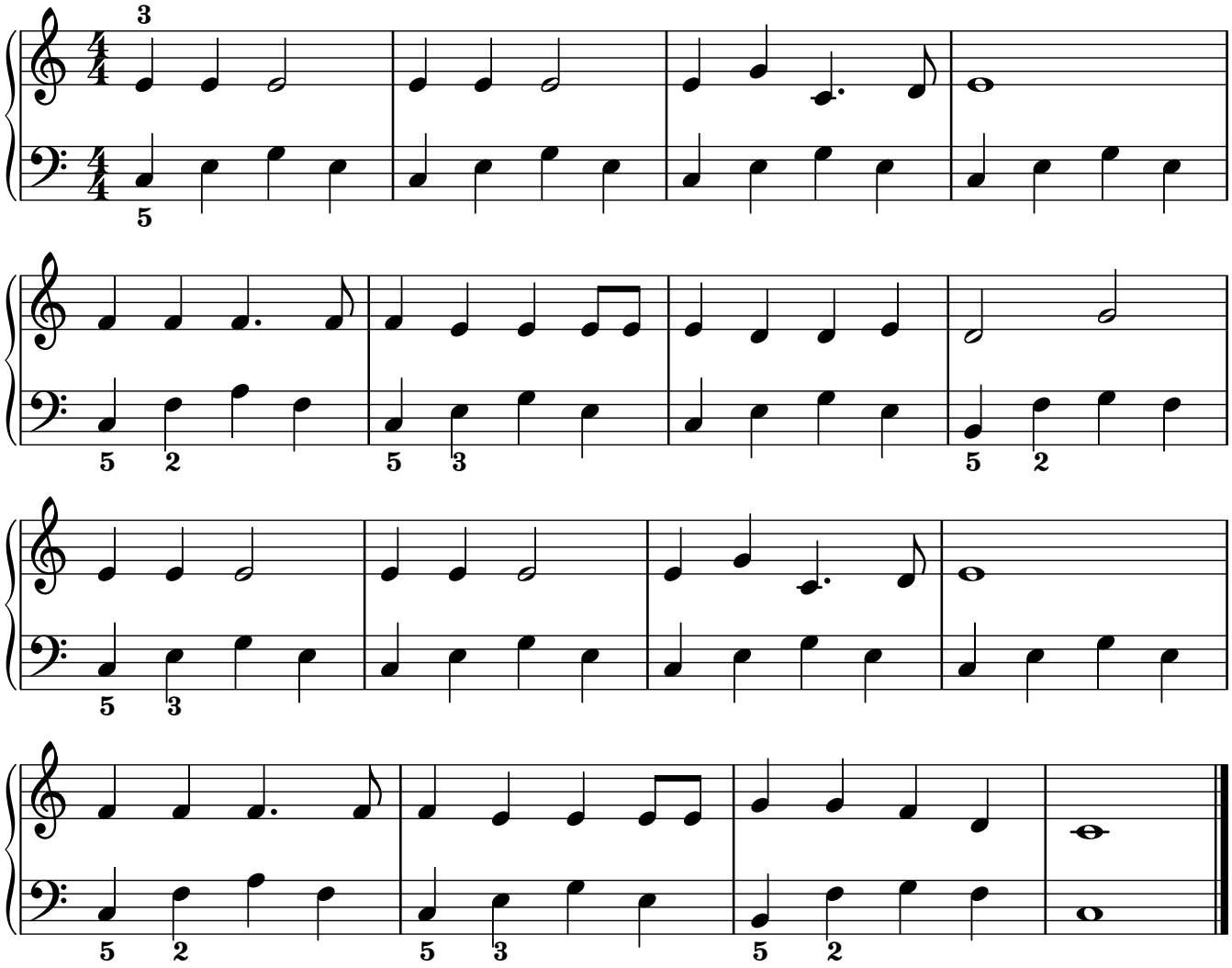
Two chords only, I and V7. In bar 4 the chord changes halfway through the bar, and in bar 8 the left hand settles on C for the last two beats.



Jingle Bells ♩ = 92

James Lord Pierpont (1857), chorus - simplified

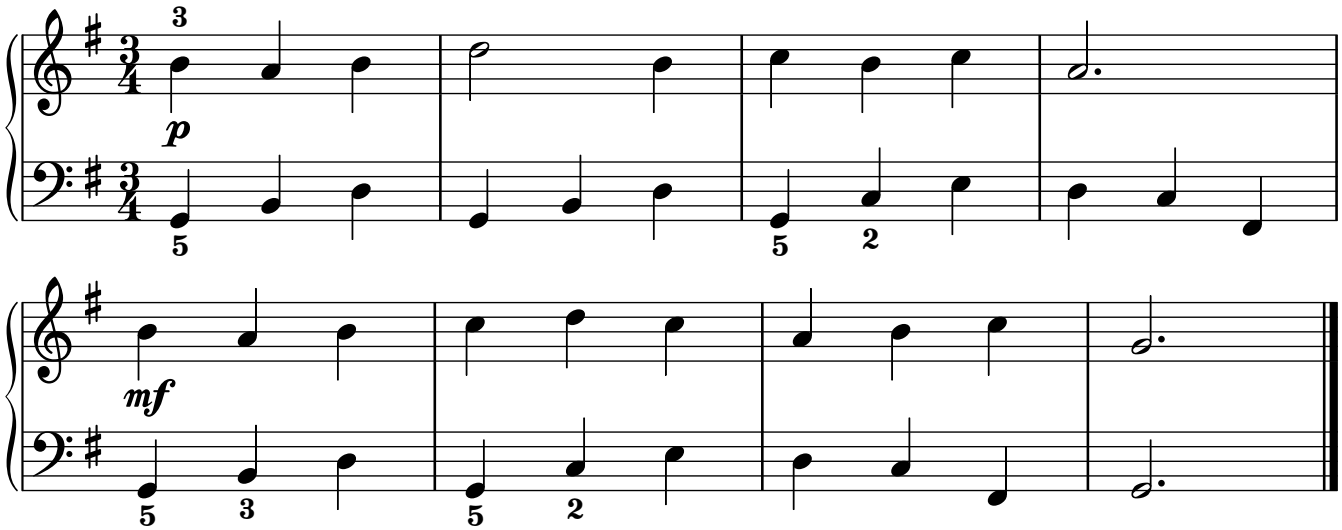
The chorus of a famous winter song, with all three chords. Find the IV shape (C F A) in bars 5 and 13 and the V7 shape (B F G) in bars 8 and 15 before you start.



Little Waltz in G ♩ = 96

Original

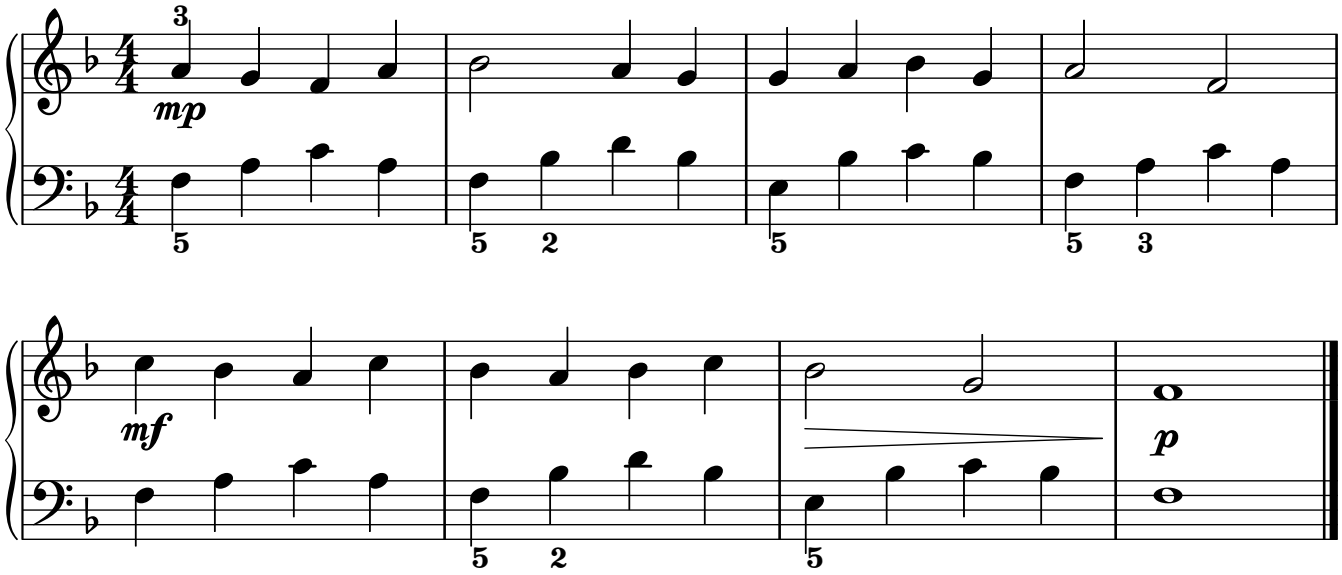
A waltz with the bass going bottom, middle, top. In bars 4 and 7 the V7 shape is played from the top down (D C F-sharp), so the hand moves only a short way.



Evening Song ♩ = 72

Original

F major, with B-flat in the right hand and in the IV and V7 shapes. The left hand's top note in IV is D above middle C, on a ledger line.



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 2?

- Play five new Part C or D exercises at the speeds shown: at most one stop each, 9 notes out of 10 right.
- Name the chord in every bar (I, IV or V7) from the left-hand shape alone.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 2.